

Los objetivos de Grammar 3 y Structure 2 van subrayados. Entregar el transcript después de la segunda escucha.

Ana: This is In the Lab FM.

Beto: There is a door in the side of a mountain, about a thousand kilometres from the North Pole, and almost nobody is allowed through it.

Ana: That sounds like a film.

Beto: It is an address. Spitsbergen, in Norway. And behind that door there are more than a million small packets of seeds.

Ana: Seeds. That is the treasure.

Beto: That is the treasure. Rice, wheat, beans, potatoes. Things nobody thinks about until the year they are gone.

Ana: Why a mountain, though? Why not a laboratory in a city, with guards and a good refrigeration system?

Beto: Because a city needs electricity. Once you depend on a power supply, you depend on everything behind it. The fuel, the road, the government, the war that has not started yet.

Ana: And a mountain depends on nothing.

Beto: The rock is frozen all year. Even if every machine inside failed tomorrow, the permafrost would hold the temperature for weeks. The refrigeration is the first defence. The mountain is the second.

Ana: How cold is cold?

Beto: Minus eighteen degrees. At that temperature some of those seeds will still germinate in a thousand years, provided that the packets stay sealed.

Ana: Sealed how?

Beto: Three layers of foil, closed with heat. Unless the foil is broken, no moisture gets in, and moisture is what kills a seed.

Ana: So the whole design is one idea, repeated. Remove the thing that can fail.

Beto: Exactly that. And it opened in two thousand eight, so the vault is younger than most of the people listening to this.

Ana: Suppose the power fails in January, in the dark, with nobody there. Then what?

Beto: Then nothing happens for a long time. That is the entire point of building inside ice.

Ana: Alright. Who owns the seeds?

Beto: Nobody who works there, and this is the part I find beautiful. The vault is a bank. Countries deposit boxes on condition that nobody else can open them. Norway owns the building. Each country owns its own box.

Ana: So the staff cannot look inside.

Beto: They cannot. As long as the depositor still exists as an institution, only that depositor opens that box.

Ana: Has anyone ever asked for their box back?

Beto: Once. And it is the reason the place exists.

Ana: Tell me.

Beto: There was a seed bank in Aleppo, in Syria. When the war made the city impossible to work in, the researchers moved to Lebanon and Morocco, and in two thousand fifteen they asked Svalbard for their own seeds back.

Ana: The backup was used.

Beto: The backup was used. They grew the plants, produced new seeds, and sent duplicates back to the mountain. The system worked scientifically, exactly as designed, and I do not think anybody wanted to celebrate.

Ana: Since we are being honest, has the mountain itself ever failed?

Beto: In two thousand seventeen, water came into the entrance tunnel. Warm weather, melting permafrost. The seeds were never in danger. The water froze before it reached them.

Ana: But the message was uncomfortable.

Beto: Very. The freezer that is supposed to survive climate change was affected by climate change. Norway spent about twenty million dollars on waterproofing and a new tunnel.

Ana: Otherwise the story would have a very stupid ending.

Beto: Otherwise, yes.

Ana: Something bothers me, though. We keep all this in case civilization has a bad century. But a seed is not a farm. Whether we save them or not, somebody still has to know how to grow them.

Beto: That is the real question, and the vault does not answer it. It preserves the genetic material. It does not preserve the knowledge.

Ana: A perfect library, and we might lose the readers.

Beto: In case that sounds pessimistic, look at what the deposits actually are. Most of them come from small farms. Varieties that one family selected, season after season, for a hundred years, because that plant survived their particular hill.

Ana: That is not industrial. That is patient.

Beto: Extremely patient. A commercial developer wants a variety that works everywhere. A farmer wants the one that works here. A geneticist will tell you the difference between those two is most of our food diversity.

Ana: And the vault keeps both.

Beto: It keeps both, and it does not decide which one was right. Genetically, it stays neutral. That decision belongs to somebody a hundred years from now.

Ana: Which is not a comfortable thought.

Beto: No. It is not even predictable. But the observation that started all of this is simple enough. If you throw something away, you should be very sure you will never want it.

Ana: Last question. If you could put one thing in that mountain that is not a seed, what would it be?

Beto: Ask me next week. I will have a worse answer by then.